



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 41

SOUTH CAROLINA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside South Carolina's family courts and child-welfare system.

53

SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 79 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
22 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 3, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
16 OF 46

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

SOUTH CAROLINA AT A GLANCE.

Across 53 South Carolina families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 79 52 of 53 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY IMPACT \$128,000 total cost across all expense categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 22 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 58.5% 52.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 53	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 52 of 53	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 16

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so South Carolina families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF SOUTH CAROLINA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	41	\$30,000	\$147,815	\$6,060,398
Lost Wages	29	\$30,000	\$144,621	\$4,194,000
Other Court Fees	22	\$3,000	\$11,348	\$249,650
Therapy / Evaluations	29	\$7,000	\$11,162	\$323,690
Reunification Services	19	\$3,000	\$8,058	\$153,100
GAL Fees	35	\$8,500	\$17,253	\$603,859
Asset Loss	21	\$100,000	\$299,762	\$6,295,000
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$128,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Mean months lost		31	2.6 yrs
Total across all families		1,003	83.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · SOUTH CAROLINA

Most families documenting in South Carolina are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		24	45%
Active case: stuck or delayed		20	38%
Case closed: within last 2 years		5	9%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		2	4%
Not in court but still affected		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		30	57%
Family Court Only		17	32%
Unknown		4	8%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	2%
Family Court		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		20	38%
3 – 5 years		10	19%
5 – 10 years		6	11%
6 months – 1 year		5	9%
Over 10 years		5	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		16	30%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		13	25%
50/50 Joint		8	15%
Full Custody		7	13%
Children in Foster Care		5	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Charleston		5	9%
Greenville		4	8%
Anderson		2	4%
Richland		2	4%
Lexington		2	4%
United States		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		24	45%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		7	13%
Other: (Short answer)		6	11%
High Conflict Divorce		3	6%
Other		3	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — SOUTH CAROLINA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable South Carolina comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Family court is where justice goes to die. All judges, attorneys, guardians ad litem, evaluators, law enforcement, child protection agencies, and anyone involved in this process in any way should be thoroughly trained and have a complete understanding of trauma and coercive [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They destroyed our family. I'm a widow, my boys and I have already lost so much. We didn't deserve this.

— SUSAN

The system has traumatized my family while allowing the abuser to lie, conceal assets, dismantle a business, and still be awarded over \$100,000 in attorney's fees.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I rebuilt my life in 4 years from nothing when we left our abuser to 6 figure salary, purchased two homes, children had security, and I was healing and thriving. Alienation claims and a notoriously corrupt attorney have taken it all away to punish us but despite the gift of PTSD [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took my children based on assumptions instead of facts, leaving us emotionally broken and fighting to be heard. No parent should lose time with their children because no one stopped to verify the truth.

— LAURA

This system has destroyed my family over false allegations and lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken my children, ripped children from their sister based on false allegations that were used knowing what the “temporary” order would entail, and almost 2 years later nothing has changed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Destroyed my life and ruined my child.

— VIRGINIA

Expose how corrupted they are and made and my children experience the worst thing ever!!!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has destroyed me and my babies mentally, and emotionally. Cause finance damage, and causing struggle

— LAWANNA

“The system repeatedly fails the ones that need it most—innocent children by enabling abusers and adding more victims to their lists. In my case, it’s his second go around and it’s “pay to play” in SC family court as I sadly continue to hear,. Around here they follow the money [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tormented my children and myself by enabling our abuser to the point of suicidal ideation in a 9 year old!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has attempted to viciously fracture my role as a mother and deteriorate my ability to provide as a newly single parent. Instead of helping us out of an abusive situation- it has acted as a method to harm us further with institutionalized and legal abuse.

— BRENNNA

Allowed my exwife to remove me from my son’s life and replace me with her new husband. Years later she still emails my place of work claiming making false claims even after my rights were terminated.

— BRENT

On top of not being able to parent my son, after years of him being in our home, my step-children have been traumatized, and my wife has been beyond depressed. The harm inflicted upon my family is immeasurable.

— THOMAS

The impact of my experience with the court system extended far beyond legal proceeding. This altered the course of my family’s stability, challenged my sense of security, and required a level of strength I continue to draw on every day.

— DONNA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They underestimated a mother's strength—no matter what this system has done, I'm still standing, and I'm coming for my son.

— PAULETTE

Completely restored not only hope in justice but teaching my son that bad behavior and lies gets rewarded

— EDEE

That have taken my child from me . I have narcissist and domestic violence.. He has a drinking problem, smoking MJ sex addiction

— JAYME

I don't know where to even start it has been a total nightmare. My children and I have lost all hope that anyone will help them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court gave my abuser custody of two of my children with no DNA proof of relation. The oldest of the two was not his but the court claimed phycological parent, the younger was never DNA tested even when I asked for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system took my child for two months for no reason, she got ahold of my straightener burnt her leg it healed fine went to 4 pediatric doctors, as well as an abuse doctor at the Julie Valentine Center, they refuse to give me the report from JVC and getting me for physical [...]

— BAILEY

They have torn my daughter from me 2 weeks after n her father died. Took her away from her brother. Broke our bond. Broke my heart. Ruined our lives!

— SHONNA

No proof given was defaulted got annilated

— ANDREW

The system has caused irreparable harm to my family. My youngest child atill hasn't dealt with the trauma she has experienced. She is terrified to be away from us now. Family court is a child trafficking ring and needs ABOLISHED!

— PETER

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It has destroyed the relationship of a child, parent, and entire family. Caused medical issues such as a bipulmonary embolism. Fear of retaliation and inability to fight for or protect a child. I am speaking for my husband as he has been gagged due to my social media.

— NICOLE

The Charleston County Family Court system, aligned with a vindictive parent, tore apart our happy family, caused trauma beyond imagination, and made it hard to even get out of bed many mornings.

— KATE

Multiple people in the DSS system repeatedly apologized and said this should never happen. I don't trust DSS leadership, I learned they are a love, hate relationship. We were great for 3 years, and then in the final hearing so many lies. DSS turned on us. In the end our [...]

— STEPHEN

The family court system has failed myself and my daughter greatly by turning the abuser into the victim and giving him full power over our lives. Ten years in and my daughter's mental health will be impacted forever.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken everything from me, torn my family apart at a cost/debt that will be paid ultimately by my children. Everyone close to me has been affected and are at a loss.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I reported concerns my child raised of department of social services. Due to multiple reports being unfounded I've lost primary custody. My ex is military and deployed and the judge is leaving my child with the step mom. Despite never being notified and her not having [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has left us fighting for our peace and safety while being told I need to trust the man who has abused me for years and continues to use the courts to hurt me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We have lost so much time, and now my daughter does not want to see or speak to me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Knowingly Prying on the bereaved., Using my already diagnosed mental health cause More mental anguish mental distress mental harm to my family, soul bound

— ROBIN

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

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— ARTHUR

The system along with my cousin and drive away so deep between me and my daughter that I don't know that it could ever be fixed and they allowed that to happen

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Too much to write here.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Financially destroy me, a father who doesn't even want his daughter just use her to destroy and hurt me, loss of trust in the system, my daughter withdrawn and in emotional distress at 6 years old

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Motivated me to expose it. All of it. Husband hid cameras in my house- secretly recording me. Had to hire 5 lawyers. Family, case law, dss, wiretapping, criminal. Women that don't have several hundred thousand dollars to fall back on never see their kids and go to prison for [...]

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39 South Carolina parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 39 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — SOUTH CAROLINA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from South Carolina families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Family court is where justice goes to die. All judges, attorneys, guardians ad litem, evaluators, law enforcement, child protection agencies, and anyone involved in this process in any way should be thoroughly trained and have a complete understanding of trauma and coercive control. The danger being imposed on children and families due to the family court crisis and lack of knowledge is unimaginable. There is nothing I have seen yet that is in the best interest of the child in this court system. It needs to be held accountable, scrutinized, reviewed, and reformed! My kids will be in therapy for life after the hell we are going through. It's all a racketeering scheme. It's truly disgraceful. More needless families will be torn apart, people will continue to lose their lives, or their livelihoods until there is real change!

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— ROBIN

The system has taken my oldest son from a large, loving family with over 30+ extended family members including three siblings that miss him dearly, and given him to a mentally sick chronically single woman who lives with her mentally sick chronically single mother. It has robbed us of every penny my wife of 12 years and I had in our retirement, savings, and bank accounts. It continues to pull us back and impose extra fines for inability to pay previous fines. We have three small children and are now forced to give up our home due to financial ruin.

— ARTHUR

The system along with my cousin and drive away so deep between me and my daughter that I don't know that it could ever be fixed and they allowed that to happen

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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Motivated me to expose it. All of it. Husband hid cameras in my house- secretly recording me. Had to hire 5 lawyers. Family, case law, dss, wiretapping, criminal. Women that don't have several hundred thousand dollars to fall back on never see their kids and go to prison for things they didn't do in these situations. God has saved us. The system has failed us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

39 full approved South Carolina comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this South Carolina report comes from South Carolina respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in South Carolina — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 53 South Carolina families reporting here are not the universe of South Carolina families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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